

The attribution report that refused to flatter itself

A marketing program I ran at an HCM software company, instrumented to answer one question honestly: did any of it actually create pipeline? Here is what it found, including the part that doesn't help me.

Prepared 2026-09-09 Program window 2026-04-01 → 2026-07-30
Source HubSpot CRM, evidence-weighted model Engagement concluded 2026-09-02

The find

One buyer in the entire cohort carried an unbroken, machine-readable trail from an AI assistant to a conversion. In mid-2026, almost nobody has this instrumented.

Therapeutic Associates Physical Therapy

LEAD SCORE 98 / 100

ORIGINAL SOURCE AI_REFERRALS — chatgpt.com

FIRST URL /dayforce-implementation?utm_source=chatgpt.com

CONVERTED ON /services/support

SESSIONS 3

EVIDENCE TIER Direct AI/AEO — weighted 100%

Then it leaked. No logged follow-up, no associated deal. The marketing program created a 98-scored opportunity and the business never touched it — which is a finding about the funnel, not about the marketing.

The ledger

Every qualified buyer lead in the program window, sorted into evidence tiers with declared weights. Weights are management contribution estimates, not causal proof.

QUALIFIED BUYER LEADS · 2026-04-01 THROUGH 2026-07-30

EVIDENCE TIER	LEADS	DEALS	OPEN PIPELINE	WON	WEIGHT	WEIGHTED
Direct AI/AEO evidence	1	0	\$0	\$0	100%	\$0
Website / content assisted	2	0	\$0	\$0	50%	\$0
Temporal correlation only	8	2	\$400,000	\$0	25%	\$100,000
Unattributed	11	5	\$15,000	\$54,000	0%	\$0
Reviewed	22	7	\$415,000	\$54,000	—	\$100,000

What moved

Whole-pipeline cohort comparison. This measures correlation and CRM traceability — the later cohort has had less time to mature.

OPEN PIPELINE — PRE-PROGRAM YTD \$4.52M 107 deals · 13 open	OPEN PIPELINE — PROGRAM PERIOD \$10.33M +128.2% · 96 deals · 32 open
OPEN DEAL COUNT +146.2% 13 → 32 active opportunities	DEAL CREATION VELOCITY −23.6% normalized · reported because it fell

What this does not claim

The limits the analysis returned. They are reproduced here rather than trimmed out, which is the only reason to trust the figures above them.

- **\$0** of open deal value is directly traceable to an owned social, SEO, AEO, or campaign touch.
- The **\$100,000** modeled figure is **0.97%** of program-period open pipeline, and it includes a 25% temporal-correlation weight.
- These are CRM attribution outcomes. They are not Search Console clicks, impressions, CTR, rankings, or GA4 sessions, and must never be presented as such.
- HubSpot's session-level traffic API was blocked and UTM coverage was incomplete. The gap between \$100K and \$10.33M is a *measurement* gap — it is not proof of zero impact, and it is not proof of impact either.

"It should not be reported externally as sourced pipeline."

Why this is the relevant experience

Same category, same buyer, and the two channels that are measurably open.

Empeon today

semrush · empeon.com · 2026-09-09

Authority score	37
Organic traffic	32.6K
Traffic from organic	93%
Paid keywords	0
Paid traffic	0
AI mentions	32
SERP presence via AI Overviews	2.7%

The two open channels

what the numbers above imply

Empeon competes with ADP, Paycom and Paylocity for healthcare operators — home care, skilled nursing, hospice, urgent care, rehab — and runs **zero paid search** against them. Ninety-three percent of its traffic rests on one channel.

Its AI surface is thin at a moment when AI referral is becoming a real acquisition path. I have a documented, instrumented example of exactly that path producing a 98-scored buyer at an HCM company.

What I'd instrument first

before spending a dollar

The lesson from the ledger is not "run more campaigns." It is that a program without complete UTM coverage and session-level traffic access cannot prove its own worth, however well it performs.

Close the measurement gap first, then open paid. Otherwise the next report reads exactly like this one — real growth, unprovable cause.

Most marketing reports are built to survive scrutiny. This one was built to apply it. The same instrumentation that produced a \$0 line is what surfaced the ChatGPT trail nobody was looking for — you do not get the second without accepting the first.

Prepared by Dillon Mohr • 2026-09-09

Figures drawn from an internal HubSpot attribution baseline generated 2026-07-15 and a YTD snapshot through 2026-07-30. Weighting: direct tracked touch 100%, verified updated-page assist 50%, temporal correlation 25%, no evidence 0%.

Empeon figures: Semrush Domain Overview, 2026-09-09, public tool output. No client-confidential data is reproduced on this page.